

The AMP Factor

Can Make Even Windows Pose as a Web Server

As a Web developer, you need a Web server but you're stuck on Windows. Yet, there's a much better world beyond IIS. We present you an overview of the free(dom) alternatives.

Developing a dynamic Web page is always fun, as well as a challenge for the Web developer. However, during recession times like this, when development of a portal right from scratch is all the more exacting and you are on the look out for a platform and development software that's free or comes with the minimum cost, a platform-independent FOSS tool is always a boon.

To begin with, WAMP (similar to a LAMP stack) is a collection of programs that has been used in combination to support Web development and can convert your Windows machine into a full-fledged Web server. WAMP is an acronym for its primary components -- Windows, Apache, MySQL and PHP/Perl/Python.

While you can find a whole gamut of WAMP packages around, we've picked up some of the best available in the Windows world.

XAMPP

XAMPP ('X' stands for cross-platform) is available for free download, and contains one of the most common Web development technologies in a single package. Its small size and portability is its USP.

XAMPP requires only one EXE file to be downloaded and runs with little or no requirement to configure the various components that make up the Web server. XAMPP is regularly updated to incorporate the latest releases of Apache/MySQL/PHP and Perl. It also comes with a number of other modules, including OpenSSL, *mod_perl*, zend optimiser and phpMyAdmin.

Self-contained, multiple instances of XAMPP can exist on a single computer, and at any given instance can be copied from one computer to another, making it very portable.

It is offered in two versions: a full (standard) version and the smaller XAMPP Lite.

Uniform Server

The Uniform Server is another WAMP package that is light (under 10 MB) and does not require installation for activation. It is thus a sought after tool by both novice Web masters and skilled developers alike, to test and develop Web applications on Windows, using FOSS.

The entire package is very portable and can be carried in a USB drive and used on any Windows system. Developers also use the Uniform Server to test their applications made with either PHP, MySQL, Perl or Apache. A number of plug-ins can be installed according to requirements. For example, a small plug-in like UniTray allows you to command and control your

server from the system tray. SlimFTPD is a small and easy to use FTP server that can be used with the Uniform Server to access your server with an FTP client.

EasyPHP

EasyPHP is another package that includes the complete AMP stack as well as easy development tools for websites and applications. It also enables a fully executable PHP. At just 15.6 MB, this is another portable application that can be easily carried on a USB. With this portable application, you can carry your developed application along with the server.

Apache2Triad

Apache2Triad bundles some of the most used open source servers and interpreters for developing Web content on the Windows platform.

The development of Apache2Triad has ceased but it has almost all the servers, interpreters and user interfaces that are already configured and ready to use. It contains Apache, MySQL, PostgreSQL, XMail (e-mail server) and SlimFTPD (FTP server). It comes with different interpreters such as PHP, Perl and Python.

Apache2Triad also makes life easy with the following GUI tools: Apache2TriadCP (control panel), phpMyAdmin (MySQL GUI), phpPgAdmin (PostgreSQL GUI), phpSQLiteAdmin (SQLite GUI), AWStats (webserver monitor), UebiMiau (E-mail client), PHPXmail (XMail GUI), and PHPsFTPD (SlimFTPD GUI).

WampServer

WampServer, formerly known as WAMP5, is a software package bundled with the AMP stack. It also comes with PHPMyAdmin and SQLiteManager to manage databases. It is one of the most used Windows Web development environments.

It is supposed to be the only solution that allows reproduction of the production server. It is possible to install all new releases of Apache, MySQL and PHP as add-ons. You can even have multiple instances of the server. Moreover, it comes with a service manager as a tray icon that allows better and easy management of the server.

There are many other similar OSS packages available.

You can find a detailed comparison of all the packages at en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Comparison_of_WAMPs. 

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